

COOPERATIVE LEADERSHIP

Key to the organizational success and staff development

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[Focused excerpts from the 24-page article - full original: cooperative-leadership-2009.pdf. Passages are verbatim; section numbering follows the original's five principles.]

The five basic principles of cooperative learning developed by David and Roger Johnson, widely applicable from education to business life: positive interdependence; face-to-face promotive interaction; individual accountability/personal responsibility; interpersonal and small group skills; group processing.

At its best, cooperation means building a social community that supports individual learning towards increased independence, through interdependence.

i) Positive interdependence

"I conceptualise it as a kind of boosting the 'we-spirit'. Even the most talented worker cannot be successful in an organization without the help of others. This is a matter of creating a shared 'space' in which everyone feels both needed and that she needs others to achieve the common goal. Everyone feels being 'in the same boat'. The success of a group depends on the success of each of its members, and the success of a member affects the success of others."

ii) Promotive face-to-face interaction

"A strong and cooperatively oriented leadership constitutes the centre for building structures that 'force' people to work together." A good leader models this interaction and knows how to tackle even hard issues constructively.

iii) Individual accountability / personal responsibility

"Individual accountability is evident when every group member feels responsible for the success of the group and also takes charge of her own share as well as possible. A well-functioning group will not accept any 'hitch hikers' (nor will it encourage 'carrying of others' burdens'). Instead, every member brings his/her own constructive input into the group performance."

iv) Social skills

The common assumption that "employees do not want to take a responsible stance" is misguided - "the issue is rather about how they are invited to participate in the discussions." A simple rule sparks conversation in any situation: "For a moment, please talk to your neighbours about what you just heard, and discuss what you perhaps did not understand or what you do not agree on."

v) Group processing

"Shared reflection helps to build a bridge from personal experiences to new theories, concepts, models and procedures." The meta-skills can be practised with questions such as: "What happened, and why? What did the action feel like? Where did we succeed, where failed? How can we improve our working methods in the future?"

On the difference this makes: "The difference between a

well-functioning organization and a less good one, then, is not so much in what is done, but rather in how it is done and how conflicts are handled."